

Lantern & Laurel

Game Design Document

3D Third-Person Mystery / Atmospheric Adventure

Draft v0.1 | Engine: Unity | Solo Developer Scope

Table of Contents

Table of Contents.....	2
0. Game Overview.....	3
0.1 Elevator Pitch.....	3
0.2 Vision Statement.....	3
0.3 Pillars.....	3
1. Narrative & World.....	3
1.1 Setting.....	3
1.2 The Predecessor's Grimoire.....	3
1.3 Mystery Arc Structure.....	3
1.4 Spirit Roster.....	4
2. Core Gameplay Mechanics.....	4
2.1 Player Movement & Traversal.....	4
2.2 Tool Interaction.....	4
2.3 Ritual / Witchcraft System.....	5
2.4 Spirit Detection & Interaction.....	5
3. Nightly Shift Structure (11 PM – 6 AM).....	5
3.1 Chore Layer.....	5
3.2 Supernatural Layer.....	5
3.3 Soft Time Pressure.....	6
3.4 Reusable Shift Template.....	6
4. First 30 Minutes Flow.....	6
5. UI/UX Direction.....	6
6. Art & Audio Direction.....	7
6.1 Visual Palette.....	7
6.2 Modeling Approach.....	7
6.3 Audio Direction.....	7

0. Game Overview

0.1 Elevator Pitch

An awkward teen takes the graveyard shift at a historic cemetery and discovers the dead are restless. Armed with mundane caretaker tools and half-remembered folk witchcraft, they spend each night between 11 PM and 6 AM balancing chores with a decades-old supernatural mystery that only the dead can finish telling.

0.2 Vision Statement

The Graveyard Shift should feel like a quiet, melancholic mystery box: cozy in its routine (sweeping paths, watering flowers, locking gates) and eerie in its escalation (chalk circles, cold spots, half-finished conversations with the dead). The chore loop is not filler around the mystery. Every system should reinforce the feeling of a lonely, competent kid doing a strange job well.

0.3 Pillars

- Routine as Ritual — mundane tasks and supernatural tasks share tools and space; one grows out of the other.
- Small Cast, Deep Mystery — few characters, but each spirit's fragment matters and interlocks with the others.
- Diegetic Everything — lantern brightness, pendulum vibration, and grimoire pages replace HUD markers wherever possible.
- Solo-Buildable Scope — one hub map, one reused shift template, four ritual verbs.

1. Narrative & World

1.1 Setting

Blackhollow Cemetery, a working historic graveyard on the edge of a small town. The player character, Wren (working name), inherits the graveyard-shift caretaker job from a predecessor who vanished under unclear circumstances — the inciting mystery.

1.2 The Predecessor's Grimoire

A leather notebook left behind by the previous caretaker. It is equal parts chore log, half-finished folk-magic recipe book, and diary. It is the player's tutorial device, quest log, and the emotional throughline of the game, the player is quite literally finishing someone else's shift.

1.3 Mystery Arc Structure

The season-long mystery is broken into a small number of Chapters, each unlocked by resolving a cluster of spirit micro-quests. Somewhere around 3–4 chapters for a v1.0 scope:

Chapter	Mystery Focus	Unlocks
1 — Settling In	Who was the predecessor, and why did they leave mid-shift?	Salt ritual verb
2 — Old Names	A cluster of graves share an erased surname — a buried town scandal.	Chalk circle verb
3 — The Ledger	A caretaker's ledger reveals the cemetery was built over something older.	Pendulum verb
4 — Dawn	The predecessor's fate is resolved; the player chooses how the haunting ends.	Brew verb + finale

1.4 Spirit Roster

Cap the roster at 4–6 named spirits for v1.0. Each needs only: a one-line identity, a one-line want, and a resolution state. Fill this table out before writing any dialogue.

Spirit	Identity / Want	Resolution States
The Gardener	Tended the grounds for 40 years; wants their unmarked plot found.	Released / Bound / Ignored
The Bell-Ringer	Died mid-argument with the town; wants the record set straight.	Released / Bound / Ignored
...	... (duplicate this row per spirit)	...

2. Core Gameplay Mechanics

2.1 Player Movement & Traversal

- Third-person walk/jog as the default pace — no dedicated sprint/stamina system for v1.0.
- Contextual, animation-driven actions only: climb-over (low walls/gates), squeeze-through, crouch-to-hide/inspect.
- Lantern doubles as flashlight and diegetic UI: brightness signals fuel, flicker signals nearby spirit activity.
- No combat-movement verbs (dodge, aim, parry) — explicitly out of scope; reinforce the non-action identity early via level design, not text.

2.2 Tool Interaction

A small, radial-wheel toolkit. Design rule: every tool has exactly one mundane use and one supernatural use, so the kit stays under 6 items.

Tool	Chore Use	Supernatural Use
Shovel	Fill graves, clear debris	Dig up buried charms / clues
Watering can	Tend plants and flowers	Fill ritual water bowls
Broom	Sweep paths and leaves	Disperse cursed ash / salt circles
Lantern	Light dark areas	Reveal spirit trails (blessed-oil fuel)
Grimoire	Log chores	Record clues, ritual recipes, spirit fragments

2.3 Ritual / Witchcraft System

Puzzle-based, not stat-based. No mana bar, no cooldowns, no spell-casting UI. Four verbs total for the entire game — new mysteries should recombine these, not introduce new ones.

- Chalk Circle — hold-and-trace a shape near a location; correct shape/size comes from a grimoire recipe.
- Salt Line — placed to ward, contain, or redirect a spirit's patrol; light stealth/puzzle layer.
- Pendulum Dowsing — held out and swung; audio/haptic intensity guides the player to clues (doubles as the quest compass).
- Brew — 2–3 ingredient combinations at a fixed brewing station, unlocked via grimoire recipe pages.

2.4 Spirit Detection & Interaction

- Ambient tells are diegetic: warm-to-cold light shift, audio stingers, unprompted lantern flicker — no HUD markers.
- Pendulum doubles as the quest compass, so no minimap or objective-marker system.
- Spirit dialogue is short branching text or voice barks.
- Every spirit micro-quest resolves into one of three standardized states — Released / Bound / Ignored-until-morning — so you build one reusable resolution system instead of one-off endings per spirit.

3. Nightly Shift Structure (11 PM – 6 AM)

3.1 Chore Layer

Each shift opens with a posted chore list of 2–4 low-stakes, always-completable tasks. Chores are the pacing skeleton; they walk the player through the map organically, replacing a separate 'explore the map' tutorial.

3.2 Supernatural Layer

Completing or attempting a chore near a haunted zone is the trigger for supernatural events. Chores gate story progression, never the reverse, so the busywork is always the delivery mechanism for the interesting part, not an obstacle to it.

3.3 Soft Time Pressure

An in-game clock runs 11 PM → 6 AM. Dawn ends the shift regardless of completion. Missed chores/mysteries roll into a lightweight reputation/notes system for the next shift, rather than a fail state.

3.4 Reusable Shift Template

Beat	Content	Purpose
Briefing	Grimoire/notebook shows tonight's chores + carryover clues	Re-orient player, surface open threads
Free-roam loop	2–4 chores, spirit encounters interleaved	Core gameplay loop
Escalation event	One scripted supernatural beat per shift	The night's 'set piece'
Dawn resolution	Log update, grimoire entry, chore recap	Close the loop, seed tomorrow

4. First 30 Minutes Flow

Goal: teach movement, chores, and tools, and introduce exactly one ritual verb (entirely diegetically, without a menu-driven tutorial).

Time	Beat	Purpose
0:00–0:03	Arrive at the shed, pick up starter tools (shovel, lantern)	Diegetic tool tutorial
0:03–0:10	First chore (sweep a path) walks player through the hub	Teach movement + interaction prompts
0:10–0:15	Scripted anomaly interrupts (cracked/glowing marker, whisper)	First hook — signals this isn't just a chore sim
0:15–0:20	Player finds the grimoire, half-buried or left behind	Tutorial device + narrative hook
0:20–0:25	Grimoire teaches the first ritual verb (salt line) via diagram	One mechanic taught, immediately applied
0:25–0:30	First spirit encounter — short, non-threatening, ends on a fragment	Establish tone; plant the season-long hook

5. UI/UX Direction

- No minimap. Pendulum + lantern behavior carry navigation and detection.
- Grimoire is the pause menu, quest log, and recipe book in one diegetic object.
- HUD limited to: lantern fuel and current chore checklist (paper-note style, corner of screen).
- Interaction prompts: minimal, contextual icon near the reticle, styled like hand-drawn caretaker notes.

6. Art & Audio Direction

6.1 Visual Palette

- Base ambient: midnight blues and desaturated greys for the 'mundane dark.'
- Warm accents: lantern practicals (orange/amber) mark safe, human-made light.
- Supernatural accent: cool cyan/teal emissives mark magical or spirit-touched objects.

6.2 Modeling Approach

- Stylized low-poly, flat-shaded or lightly baked materials; lean on lighting and fog, not geometric detail, for atmosphere.
- Shared humanoid rig across player and all spirit NPCs to reuse animation packs.

6.3 Audio Direction

- Diegetic-first sound design: wind, distant bell, footsteps on gravel/grass as the 'silence' the supernatural interrupts.
- Spirit stingers should be short, tonal, and non-jumpscare; melancholy over horror.